

Introduction

Earth is an astonishing place. Somehow, a mass of gas and shattered rock swirling around a hot star evolved into a living planet, unique in the Solar System.

By sheer luck, Earth formed at exactly the right distance from the Sun for water to lie on its surface without freezing or boiling away into space, forming broad oceans that cover more than two-thirds of the globe. Water seeping down into the searingly hot rocks below makes them melt and erupt from volcanoes—a process that, over billions of years, has created immense continents.

Circulating air currents in the atmosphere carry moisture over the land. There, it soaks into the ground and fuels the growth of plants—just one aspect of the incredible web of life that makes Earth so special. As part of that life, we in turn have changed the face of our planet in countless ways.

Using a rich combination of vivid images and clear text, this book is the perfect guide to how planet Earth works, and what humanity has made of it. It covers every aspect of its geography, from its formation and structure to its turbulent weather, restless geology, living landscapes, and the countries and peoples of the world. This is our planet, in all its glorious complexity.

